The Unbreakable Bulwark

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/74113051.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F, Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Original Female Character/Original Trans Character, Original Female Character/Original Female Character, Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra)

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Part 8 of Defiance - Raised in Halfmoon AU

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The Unbreakable Bulwark

by tp9829, Zelenal

Summary

Before the Dr'adeths Coup.
Two Gangs, both alike in indignity,
In foul Wastes, where we lay our scene,
From ancient grudge break to new mutiny,
Where uncivil blood makes innocent hands unclean.

Notes

I would like to thank Zelenal for making this readable, and for Aoife for coming up with the original idea of this AU, which has spiraled out of control. You can find out more on the Defiance Discord

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Chapter 1: Death in the Sands, Love in the Woods

Chapter Notes

- Content Warning:

An Abandoned Horde Outpost

The Edge of the Crimson Wastes

The Crimson Wastes

Etheria

Five Years Before the Coup Attempt

The base was completely ransacked—of course it was. Everything of value was taken long ago: the skiff outside had its engine removed, the computer terminals taken apart by scavengers, the only thing left were boxes full of brown bars that no one dared touch. She shoveled one into her mouth. It tasted like something undefinable but sweet, like chocolate but with more chew. It was not something she would normally eat, but at least it was calories; she needed it, she was famished.

Shelter from the blistering heat, something approaching clean water (the filter was probably broken, but at least it sprayed something that wasn't poisonous, just metallic tasting) and several ration bars: this base was as close to paradise as a condemned woman could reach.

She tried to hope: she hoped it was safe to rest, she hoped her family wouldn't follow her, she hoped Ella was safe. But this is the Crimson Waste; hope came here to die. She couldn't hope to hope, she had to do what she needed for herself. Erika the Exile, hunted by her family, what the fuck kind of hope could she

manage. No, she could do what was needed. She clambered halfway to her feet, struggling against the exhaustion in her bones.

She needed to fill up her water bottles, she needed to set up a clean space to sleep, she needed to cover her tracks so that no one could find her, she needed to count out the rations to see how far she could make, she needed to strip that old skiff for anything useful—no engine but other parts of the hull might be worth something. She needed to do all these things.

She threw up on the sand instead. She was on her knees retching up the brown bars. They tasted good. Filling even. If this is how Horde Soldiers ate, maybe they had something good going on, better than what they could scavenge from Stoneskin lizards and the four types of non-poisonous plants in the wastes (three of which were brewed into various alcohols). But, despite that, she wasted it by spewing it onto the floor. Sand and Ash, her mentor would skin her alive if he saw so much wasted water. She had no idea what had made her so sick.

He was dead now; she had killed him when he had found out the truth. Drove a knife into his cold heart—good riddance to that lizardfolk scumbag. She tried to sit up. The sand was already eating the moisture, leaving only chunks of foul-smelling, half-digested food. She pushed herself back against the wall of the building. She had to find a way to move on. Her family would only be a day or so behind and, in her condition, they would kill her and wipe away the mistakes she and Ella had made. Soon, they would both be forgotten.

Ashes, they were stupid. Her and Ella knew they would get caught, but they were dumb—stupid hormones, stupid Ella, stupid rules, stupid feud—and, worst of all, she was so fucking stupid. Getting roped into that whole mess.

She had managed to stagger inside her haven. She could hide here until nightfall, try to rest. Exhaustion clung to her like leaden weights. She could then make a break across the desert, try to

make it to the western edge of the Whispering Woods. What had her life come too, that she would risk the absolute death trap of the Whispering Woods over the safety of the Crimson Wastes?

She grabbed her bag from where it had fallen, carefully filling the empty space with the rations she had found. Then she filled her waterskin with the metallic-tasting water. She was doing things by rote as he had taught her, with mechanical precision to survive the desert—she could only think of the surprise and betrayal on his face when he had found out the truth. She cleaned her wounds with the same spray. She hoped none of them were infected and chuckled again, they probably were, 'hope for nothing and you are never disappointed.' her mother had said to her once. She had tried to stick by that mantra, but it all came apart, when she found herself hoping for her…

She was crying again, wasting water—Fuck!—but she couldn't stop. She had cried and cried in the safety of her home. She had told her she never wanted to see her again just so that she would stay away and stay safe. But she could never listen. She just *had* to see her one last time and, like every good thing in the Crimson fucking Wastes, it fell apart, the forbidden fruit becoming ash in her mouth.

She slammed her hand against the wall and felt something crack, whimpering as she fell to the ground. It was a few hours till sundown. She could just close her eyes against the warm metal, let the tears dry. Fuck, she was so tired. If she was lucky, someone would find her; if she was unlucky, someone she knew would find her…

The tent was warm, still holding the heat of the daymoons. She had been resting in it alone. Her hunt had gone well; she would be rewarded by the family for bringing back such a large beast. It's leathery hide would make good armour, its meat would feed several members of the family, and it's bones would make good weapons. She had spent most of the afternoon sharpening one of the teeth she had removed into a long knife. Now, though, she lay against the warm rock around which she had pitched her tent.

The coiled body of the serpent was loaded onto a cart and, come morning, she would make her return.

The tent flap pushed open and she was backlit against the setting moons, wearing her heavy cloak wrapped around herself and her bow slung over her shoulders. Her hair was short and slightly shaggy, falling down to the tips of her ears over her dark skin. A patch of stubble grew on her cheeks—she hadn't had time to shave if she wanted to make tonight's meeting. She was the most beautiful thing in this damned land. Her eyes went wide seeing her.

"I doubted you would be here." She fell down next to her, into Erika's open arms. "I thought it would be too risky." She nuzzled closer to her—they hadn't seen each other in three weeks, and then it was on a battlefield fighting over a small oasis of water.

"For you," she kissed the woman's head, "I would risk everything." She ran a hand through her hair, stopping before she reached her cheek—she knew that would hurt her. Instead, she dropped her hand down to her shoulder and pulled her in for a kiss. It was like lightning from a sandstorm and, like a sandstorm, it stripped everything bare. Their lips broke apart so she could mutter out "Ella" like a prayer; the woman shivered beneath her. Then they were kissing again, cloaks thrown aside.

They had lain there on the slowly cooling stone after—that night had changed so much— she had offered to help clean her up before the long journey back. It was tender and soft, the kind of thing that she had never in her wildest dreams imagined having. She had used her new knife sharpened to a razor's edge to carefully shave her, leaving only a little nick to remind her of their old rivalry. Ella had winced at that but smiled. Two warriors—they were never meant to meet, never meant to be together.

As the daymoons rose, they parted. She was clothed, wearing her dust cloak. The tent was packed into the cart alongside the carcass of the sandsnake. Ella had come up behind her and wrapped her into the softest embrace she had experienced since

the death of her mother. She turned to lay a kiss on her lover's tender lips—

She startled awake to a noise. The memory of that night was raw in her skull. She gripped one hand onto the snaketooth knife she kept near her at all times; her other arm was clutched around her belly.

The noise was tiny, a slight groaning of metal. To anyone else, it wouldn't have even been acknowledged, but she had to stay awake, had to get away. She drew the knife slowly. She had covered her tracks well, hidden in an alcove that was once a bed for the computers used in this place; it wasn't comfortable but it was hidden.

She could try to run—the night had fallen, she was probably behind schedule—but, if she was lucky, her family had passed her. If she was lucky, it was some curious animal: a sandsnake snakelet or a Southern Stalker Spider. Big enough to bend the metal, but not an active threat if she was careful.

She slipped from the alcove with the grace of an expert hunter of the Dawn Vipers family. She had been trained since she could walk to move silently. She crept to the edge of the room, and cracked open the door. In the central room, he stood wrapped in a snakeskin cloak, clutching a large cudgel made of repurposed metal. Elder Aridan, her father. His head snapped to the doorway as it had cracked open.

"Daughter, come out. I will not hurt you." He used to say those words lovingly, when she had played a prank in the village. Now, she could hear the lie behind those words. Still, there was no way out; the room she was in was well hidden but the only exit was through this room. He had found her; the family wouldn't be far behind.

She stepped out, knife raised. He was good, but old; she could slip past him easily enough. She would have to abandon her supplies but, if that meant getting away safely, then she would.

Anything to survive. *How did you track me?* She had meant to ask or *Will you let me leave?* Both questions that needed answering.

"What did you do to her?" it wasn't the question she was expecting herself to ask. Clearly, from his expression, it wasn't the question he'd expected to hear. He cocked his head, tightening his grip on the shaft of his makeshift mace. She stared at him, deep brown eyes meeting those that had taught her how to hunt and how to sew and how to fight. Her own eyes were exhausted, bags that you could carry water in, deep set and sunken. She had shed weight in the last week. Unhealthy. He took a step towards her, then stopped himself.

"The Bellheart Clan bastard who came limping to our territory?" he asked as if he didn't know exactly who she meant. She waited for an answer, gripping the knife tighter. "We dealt with her." Her heart clenched; she wanted to throw up but there was nothing in her stomach. She remained standing. "You should return to the family," he implored. He sounded genuine. "Please, Erika, this was a mistake. You are young, the others will forgive you after that Bellheart assassin killed Luka. We had to string her up as an example." So, *that's* the lie he would go with, that he had convinced himself it was true. Every word that left his mouth was drowned out by the drumbeat of her own heart. "We can cut it out, get that parasite out of you, and then we can return. You will have the minimum punishment but then…" *What parasite,* she thought, but he had lowered his guard.

She lunged, swift and sudden, like the viper she was taught to emulate. He threw himself backwards, over the crate she had left in the middle of the room, bringing up the wicked looking mace. She just needed to get to the door, maybe snatch up the bag of supplies. His eyes followed to where she was staring and, in one fluid motion, he whirled around, grabbing the bag and holding it in one hand. "I am not letting you leave. You will come back to the family as someone deceived and willing to earn their freedom back after we cut out that thing in you. Or you can come back in chains disgraced. Maybe the Horde will buy you." He was snarling at her, like a feral animal. *They wanted to fucking cut her open!*

She stalked around the table, blade unsheathed and clutched in her right hand. He held up the mace in a defensive stance. She stepped forwards into his space; he swung the Mace down, towards her stomach. What fucking bastards her family was. She brought her right arm round to catch the brunt of it, protecting her stomach. Tossing the knife from her right hand and catching it with her left, she swung.

Blood sprayed across her face, her left arm juddered with the shock of cutting to the bone, arterial spray guttered across the room, mixing with the remains of the bile they had been standing in from earlier. She went to grab the bag that had toppled from his fingers, but her right arm was fucked, unable to hold onto anything. Her body was exhausted, and now she was a kinslayer. Sheathing the blade, she took the bag on her left side. No turning back; Ella was dead. Keep moving; her family would sell her to Horde if they didn't string her up for the vultures. One foot in front of the other.

The Whispering Woods beckoned. The night was dark, the moons covered in a layer of clouds. A sandstorm was coming; she could tell that if she was blind and deaf. Good. It would strip her father's corpse to the bone and throw the family off her trail.

She walked for Ash-knows how long. Her feet bleed, she had tripped over more than one root and twisting vine, her body was bruised, her skin welting, her arm was broken in more than one place. But she couldn't stop for more than a second. Each time she fell, she wretched. *Fucking Ella, what did you do to me?* She could barely pick herself up. *Fucking Dad trying to kill me?* No one said it would be this painful. *Fucking Mom, why did she leave me?*

The daymoons had risen and set, and still she walked. Her stomach growled, her throat was sand, she could feel the sheer weight of fatigue, her body wanted to collapse, her mind was screaming. She had gone as far as her willpower could take her. Maybe here wasn't so bad. Her eyes unfocused as she looked around at the small clearing. A tree, that's what people called the things in the Whispering Woods. It had grown around a small

structure made of glass. It was cool, *or was she just cold?* She could be dying. *Did she care?* She leaned against the bark of the tree, put her left hand on her belly, and went to sleep.

The Healer's Hut

Elberon

Bright Moon

Etheria

Five Years Before the Coup Attempt

"Found her out by the shrin—"

"Malnourished and these injuries, she's been atta—"

"Gang markings. I don't recogni—"

She opened her eyes slowly. This wasn't the moonless land. She felt parched still; her arm was stiff and she looked down at it to find it had been bound in some kind of cloth and held in place with wood.

She went to lift her other arm and felt the tug of some wire, which fed into a bag of water? Right into her body. A figure moved into her vision holding a clipboard in a clawed hand. It was a feline hybrid; dark grey fur with patches of black. Her ears twitched slightly at the rustling noise and she turned to face her. Maybe a year older than her.

"Oh, you're awake. Good job. You gave me quite the scare." The woman had approached her bed. She had beautiful green eyes that stared at her. "I found you during my early morning supply run curled up against a tree. My name is Melody, Melody Leor. I said I'd keep watch over you."

She glared at the woman, the kind of glare she had given to other gang members to get them to shut up. It worked nine times out of ten. This woman was a tenth.

“Getting you back here was a trek. You talk in your sleep.” The woman barreled on through her glare like it was made out of sand. Perhaps it was, hooked up to a strange water machine and her arm sealed in wood. It wouldn’t be hard to escape, but she was still too tired to rush this woman and fight her way free. “You kept talking about someone called Ella?”

She froze at that. Whatever what they had given her, it had filled up her body enough that she could sob again; it came out strangled. The woman took her hand and let her squeeze. “That’s it, darling, let it out.” She had heard over the sobs; her water discipline had gone to shit. She needed to reign this in before they cut whatever rations they gave her. “I am sorry for your loss.” The hybrid had rubbed circles on her back with her other hand.

It took a few minutes for her to get the tears under control and, after she did, the woman sat back away from her. “I have to ask some questions.” Erika braced for those: once they realized they were treating a criminal, they wouldn’t be as kind. Sensing her tense, the other woman said in a placating tone, “Whatever you answer, know that you will be safe here, as will your child.” She froze at that.

“What child?” she heard herself saying, her ears ringing. The woman stopped and looked at her, her eyes going wide and her tail lashing anxiously. Her good hand went to her stomach. No wonder she hadn’t been able to keep food down. That was a symptom right.

“Oh, stars.” The woman stepped backwards. “It’s safe, your baby,” the woman started to stammer. “Healthy at eleven weeks, at our best guess. Oh, I’m not good at this, I was just here to check your medication. I’ll get a midwife.” The woman darted out of the room.

She held a hand over her stomach. She was having a baby. Ash and Sand, how was she going to take care of it…

Melody's Home

Elberon

Bright Moon

Etheria

Two Years Before the Coup Attempt

Erika awoke from another nightmare, of her in chains and Ella or Melody being killed by the family. She had those with such frequency enough now that she was taking Melody's advice and making the long skiff trip to the Shining City once a month for an appointment with a specialist in healing the mind. She had resisted for months but, after the birth and the low mood that followed, Melody had taken her.

She was going once a month; it was too long a journey for more than that. But it was helping her slowly. 'Any progress was good progress but it doesn't have to be linear'. She sat up slowly, feeling the shift of weight next to her on the bed, and grabbed her journal, and began to scribble the contents of her dream down. She hated doing it, but seeing the pattern and knowing that it couldn't happen here helped. Elberon was too far from the Wastes, and too far from the Horde. Her family was safe.

Melody had helped her recover slowly, and then been there for her through the pregnancy and, seven months later, her little troublemaker was born. She spent all her free time with Melody now, the two had become inseparable, far more than just her patient. They had gone into a union (a marriage they called it here) a year before after she had held a funeral for Ella (another thing her therapist recommended) to close that chapter of her life.

Her wife sat up and wrapped herself around her back, placing her tail in her lap. “Go out or stay in?” her wife asked an old question. Sometimes she needed the security of being in the community, and sometimes she needed to wander. Exploring the surrounding woods was nicer than exploring the dunes of the Wastes. Both helped in different ways. Melody trailed a claw down one of her old tattoos.

“In,” she said after a minute. “I have to take our little troublemaker out; it’s her birthday after all.” She felt her wife smiling as she kissed the old tattoo of a snake between her shoulder blades—her wife liked that one a lot.

She lay back down and her wife clambered on top of her and started purring and soon she drifted back to a much calmer sleep. She dreamt of her family together; she missed Ella dearly, but she had fallen so in love with Melody and, at some points, she hated herself for that.

When she next awoke, it was to her little troublemaker clambering on the bed. It was her birthday, after all. She went to move to grab her but Melody was faster, scooping her up with a purr. As she purred, her kid tried to imitate her mother by humming. It was surreal. To this day, she sometimes thought that she had died that night against her father.

She loved Melody with all her heart, but sometimes she wished that Ella had lived to see their little troublemaker grow up. She looked just like her: the same frown when she didn’t get what she wanted, the same hazel eyes, a hopeful look that was foreign to both of them until that fateful day at Da’she canyon.

The nightmare had settled; she was safe, she would treat her daughter for her birthday. The fears that had ruled her since she was a toddler wouldn’t rule her life any longer, wouldn’t rule her child’s life. She was still a pessimist but seeing Melody gently playing with her kit, she began to do that terrible thing: she began to hope.

Town Square

Elberon

Bright Moon

Etheria

One Year Before the Coup Attempt

Melody had a busy morning. After seeing off Erika to Bright Moon, she had dropped off the packages for the Osters, mixed up several poultices to treat the cows of the Filis' farms, and then had to set a broken leg, all while keeping an eye on her kit.

That girl could get into trouble so easily. She was rambunctious, liked to start fights like her mother—both her biological mothers, she supposed. She had only heard stories about Ella from her mate, obviously, but the woman seemed fierce, brave, and loyal to her until the end. She should feel some jealously—even after imprinting, her mate still felt so much for this poor, dead woman but, instead, she was glad that it brought the little terror currently trying to throw a rock at a way to distant scarecrow while her mama discussed what not to do with the poultices to Old Lady Filis.

After a few minutes, assured that the woman wouldn't try to feed them to her cows, she gathered up the girl into her arms, and she nuzzled her like a Magicat kitten would. The girl had never known Ella; Erika refused to talk about it with her until she was older, so it was always Mom and Mama.

The journey back to town took only fifteen minutes or so. Passing by people she knew from life in such a small village, her own hat shaped like the mushrooms the farms cultivated sat carefully cut around her ears. Her kit kept pulling it off. Sometimes, when she was younger, she chewed on it. She had stopped that recently.

It was all so easy, she had stopped at Sara's to pick up a treat for the three of them—something nice and sweet for after dinner—when everything went to shit: the top of the town clocktower exploded in a bolt of green energy.

There was panicked shouting, people screaming, the sound of rumbling, the distant acrid stench of lightning and ozone that made her fur go on end. She knew she wouldn't be any help here. In her arms, her kid started screaming. She tried to soothe her, shushing around the screams. She had to make her way back home. Then they would be safe. She rounded onto her street.

That's when she saw them: a banner of red wings on a background of sickly green, dozens of soldiers wearing metal uniforms and carrying strange rods of metal she knew to be blasters of some kind. Behind them, a huge armoured vehicle was driving through a house. She turned to run, and one of the Horde soldiers spotted her.

A shot burned her shoulder, jolting her body and almost throwing her to the ground. She had to get out. Get to somewhere safe. The soldiers were following her as she ran—of course Horde soldiers would follow a fleeing woman carrying a child. Scum. The wall of the city was torn apart in places, but she ran through a gap, the soldiers too stunned by someone running through them with catlike grace to shoot at her. Her shoulder burned, though, and the weight of carrying a child slowed her enough.

One or two of the soldiers turned from their attack to follow her. She screamed as she ran, saying that she was no soldier but she was a healer, that she worked with plants and made medicine. In her arms, her child was screaming, crying. The soldiers followed unrelentingly.

The Whispering Woods would protect her. The thought was solid in her mind. She rushed for the trees, blaster bolts burning around her. Erika had taught her in a blaster fight to be unpredictable, to dodge and duck in different directions, and her wife's instincts for battle kept her alive. Erika taught her and her

child so that, if a fight ever came to Elberon, they would be safe. It almost worked. She had crossed the river, she was at the edge of the treeline when she felt her leg give out from under her. She looked down to see a hole the size of an apple pit burnt through her thigh; it had seared the nerve endings closed.

Looking down also showed hazel eyes wide with terror, trying to hum calm into her mama. She steeled herself. Get into the trees, search through her bag—she had to have something. She would crawl if she had to. She threw her whole body behind one of the trees, falling against her injured arm to keep the toddler she carried safe. That was the most important thing.

She crawled, the child held against her side, her bad arm screaming in agony. She could see it, the old crystal building where she had met Erika. Surely the Horde wouldn't find her here. She pulled herself up against the tree into the same position she had found Erika all those years ago. She was about to find a way to dig into her bag without letting go of her kid when she heard voices. Voices speaking in a language she hadn't spoken since her father died eight years ago.

"Are you certain this is the rendezvous?" a female voice asked. She peered around the tree. In front of the building were three Magicats: a middle aged woman (the speaker), a slightly older man dressed in fine regalia, and a boy no older than fifteen.

"Yes, wife, I am certain." He sniffed the air. "We are not alone." Melody ducked her head back behind the tree when the older magicat rounded to face her. "Who are you?" he snarled, claws unsheathing.

"Please." Her voice was hoarse with pain. "Please don't hurt us!" She was begging. "I'm a herbalist, I just wanted to get away."

The man glared down at her—she could feel his utter contempt. The woman and teenager had joined him. The woman sneered at her then her ears drooped slightly. She was staring at the child in her arms.

“Kellam, can’t you sense it?” the woman asked hurriedly. “That child, she has raw magical potential greater than I have ever seen.” Melody’s eyes went wide, her ears pinning back in fear. She clutched the trembling child close to her. “Take it. Shadow Weaver will enjoy having a new toy.”

Melody tried to stand, to run, but, on her leg, she succeeded in only tripping and crawling a few paces. The man had said something, and the boy had talked hurriedly; she wasn’t listening to their conversation. She tried to crawl, clutching her precious bundle in her arms. She didn’t make it far.

The boy stepped up next to her. He offered a hand out to her. She stared at it like a viper. “Please,” the boy said, “I just want to help you.” He sounded sincere, and terrified. She looked over at the boy's parents—they must be his parents—who were arguing into a comms device.

“You're going to take my daughter?” Her voice was quiet. “Why should I trust you?” She could make a break for it, run back to the town. Surely the Horde were better than this.

“You shouldn’t; I’m a traitor,” the boy said in a way that broke her heart. “But I can at least see that your leg doesn’t get infected, and set your arm. Please, just let me help. What’s your name?”

She looked up. Her injuries meant nothing if she could get back to town, but she wasn’t an idiot. She wasn’t going to make it back to town like this. This boy seemed sincere in his self-loathing. “Melody,” she settled on saying.

He nodded. “My name is Gideon. I am going to start with the leg, okay?” He talked with the practised skill of a combat medic—she had met a few of them before, Rebellion fighters. He was talking to keep her distracted from—yep, there it was, ice cold shot up her leg, burning. She knew to expect it and it still hurt. She yowled in pain, and her kid curled up closer against her.

“I’m sorry, but that won’t get infected, and it may heal over naturally. I’ve promoted growth.” He knew a spell to promote tissue growth, and he was working with the Horde. This kid was suddenly more terrifying than the tanks that had nearly ran through her house. “What’s her name?” He gestured gently at the child held in her arms, trying to hum like she purred.

“You’re going to take her from me. You’re going to kill her.” She was babbling. He just looked like a broken kit. Over his shoulder, it seemed the conversation on the comms was ending.

“I am. I am so sorry for that.” The boy looked like he would rather run into a Horde battlefield than do what he was about to do. “I cannot promise you much, Melody, but I promise she’ll survive today, and so will you. Now, please, what’s her name?”

She wanted to scream, to try and run on her fucked up leg. She could only cry, and whisper hushed assurances to the child in her arms who tried to grab onto her fur. The boy's father was storming over; he lacked any kindness the boy, this Gideon, had shown.

With trembling claws, she held the young child up and kissed her on the forehead. “Lonnie,” she said. “I— We love you so much, Lonnie. Please never forget that.”

The boy swallowed something in his throat, tears in his eyes like the ones that were streaming down her face. He gently muttered a spell and consciousness retreated from her and Lonnie both. She heard shouting, but her baby was asleep in the hands of a traitor. She should be dead…

Chapter 2: Breaking the Bulwark

Chapter Summary

A child has been taken to the Fright Zone, she will grow, to one day face a terrible destiny.

Chapter Notes

Thanks again to Zelenal for making this far more readable.

▶ Content Warnings:

Cadet Dormitories

Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Year Before the Coup Attempt

When Lonnie woke up, it was dark. That wasn't bad; she liked the dark, it was comfortable. Mom and Mama both used to say that "There's nothing scary in the dark" and she had gotten used to it. Mama even wandered around in the dark like it was the middle of the day. What *did* make her bite her lip in worry was that she wasn't in her bed, she wasn't in Mom and Mama's bed, and she wasn't in the healer's hut's bed (Mama complained she spent too much time there.)

Instead, it was warm; much warmer than her bed ever got, warm in a bad way that made her skin sticky with sweat and there was someone nearby who was crying, but trying not to, like Mom did some days. She could hear the short breaths, but much higher

than mom's like it was Dirk or Amelia, her two best friends, but they just cried; they didn't hide it.

She frowned as she stood up. She felt the room shift under her, and had to hold onto what appeared to be a bedpost. She felt that her clothes were different, more rough against her skin. That was annoying; she liked her clothes and Mama said she would only change her if she was hurt. She didn't feel hurt, she just felt tired. Something was clearly wrong.

She walked slowly, getting over to the sound of crying, and found it was another bed—two beds in one room? She climbed up onto it and found there was a girl there, crying and shaking nearly silently.

"Hey, it's okay." she said. It probably wasn't okay; why was no one coming to check on her? Where was the light switch? "It's just dark. Nothing scary in here." She tried to sound brave. Her mama always said she was brave.

The sniffling stopped for a moment, then a hand reached out blindly and touched her own. They had skin like an Etherian, not a hybrid. She held onto that hand. "It'll be okay," she said it firmly. If she believed it was true, then it would be true. The shaking slowed but didn't stop.

Suddenly, a doorway opened and light poured in. She blinked away the sudden change, then looked around, her breath catching. She wasn't in Elberon at all. This was somewhere from her nightmares. Green metals clung to a room with a lot of beds. Sitting in the bed with her was a girl with blonde hair hanging loose past her ears. She was clearly terrified. Across from her opposite the bed she had climbed out of was a boy around her age with straw-coloured hair, and clutched in his arms was a lizardfolk hatchling. Like Dirk: small enough that the boy could still lift him in one arm. They were all her age or similar. Maybe they could be friends.

Standing in the doorway was a Monster: tall—taller than Mom or Mama—wearing a long robe of dark red that seemed to move even though there was no wind and her face was made of wood, cut to look like a monster from the storybooks. It didn't walk, it floated with a noise like the wind through the trees of the woods when it was the middle of the night. The figure entered the room, looking like everything Lonnie had been taught to fear. She wondered for a moment if this was one of Mom's family that she pretended not to be scared of.

It turned its gaze on the shivering girl who stilled suddenly, like she was held in a vice. Then its gaze turned towards her and, with a voice like a spider's trap, it said, "Cadet Lonnie Leor, walk with me." Cadet? She wasn't a cadet. But the voice was not one she wanted to argue with. She let go of the girl's hand.

She walked out, following the Monster. The corridor was long and the Monster stopped at a window. Lonnie got up on her tip toes, sticking out her tongue in concentration to get up high enough to see through it. The Monster had put her hands behind her back, clasping them like the town guard did sometimes. Without looking at her, the thing addressed her.

"Do you know where you are, Cadet Lonnie?" Lonnie shook her head and the woman turned to glare at her—she could tell she had done something wrong. "You will use your words, child, or did your mongrel parent fail to teach you to speak?" Lightning—red like a rose—arced around the Monster's fingers.

Terror gripped Lonnie; she knew instinctively that she was in danger. Did this monster eat children and that's why the girl was so afraid? "No," she settled on saying, small. She sounded so small.

"What question was that an answer to, child?"

"The fi-first one," she stammered. "I don't know where I am. Where is Mom and Mama?" The fear was building in her.

“I am sorry, child, but your mothers are gone, and they have left you in my care.” The woman's voice had softened to something akin to honey. She froze. Mom and Mama had left her to a Monster? That couldn’t be right. Mom always said she would fight monsters for her. “You can call me Shadow Weaver.” So, she had been left with a Monster. The woman continued. “You have been left in the care of myself and Lord Hordak.” Lonnie took a quick breath—everyone knew about Lord Hordak, he conquered the Empire of the Nest and ate the Princess of it. He was the biggest monster of all. The creature, Shadow Weaver, ignored the interruption. “You have been brought to me because of your great… potential. You are now a cadet. One day, you may rise to greatness under my tutelage; I will be affording you special privileges.”

Lonnie tried to hum, to calm her nerves like Mama does to her when she’s upset. “I want to go home. I want to see Mom and Mama.” The Monster rounded on her. Terrifying shadows clawed up out of the ground. But Lonnie was brave, she was taught not to be scared of monsters, despite the small whimper that escaped her throat she stood her ground. After a second, Shadow Weaver calmed.

“You are strong, child; few stand up to me without looking away in terror. You will do well here, Cadet. Your mothers are gone; I am sorry for that. But you have a new home here. You and I,” she put a hand on Lonnie's cheek, cradling her face like mom did to her sometimes—she leaned into the touch for a second, “will do great things together…” The woman retracted her hand after a second of contact. “Now, come. Let us introduce the rest of your squad, they will be your family from here…” Lonnie followed the woman back into the room.

Training Sim Area

Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

The Day of the Coup Attempt

The training sim wasn't meant for them; it was meant for a full squad of cadets, not a half-strength squad of junior cadets. The three of them—Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio—were running through something designed for kids twice their age with Lonnie left in charge. Adora had been sent off to medical for some reaction to something she didn't know about.

So, Lonnie had been left with Kyle and Rogelio to run through a dangerous test of their skills. She would manage—one foot in front of the other, get to the goal. That's all that mattered. But the boys—Kyle was an active detriment to their skills in this situation. Give the boy a tablet and he could crack it with practised ease, give him a skiff and he could pilot it better than any adult she knew, give him a blaster and he was likely to shoot his own foot by accident. As for Rogelio, she loved Rogelio. He was a comfort, something familiar in this messed up world she was abandoned into, but Ash and Dust, she couldn't rely on the scrawny creature to put up much of a fight. Shadow Weaver believed that, one day, he would grow to be amongst the biggest Lizardfolk in the Horde, but she didn't see how. At the moment, he was two foot-nothing of scales and ideals.

So, that left her, and she was good. Her staff rang out as it struck another of the bots simulated to look like a Princess. Rogelio would help, but it was down to her to finish the course in a decent time so Shadow Weaver didn't "intercede in their efforts." If Adora was here, well, the two of them were a team. In the year she'd been here, Adora had become a real friend. She had spent her nights helping Adora out with her fear of the dark, and Adora talked her through life in the Horde. She had been here the longest, alongside Rogelio, and she was supposed to be here helping her fight. Instead, she got sick; Adora was always sick. She knew she was afraid of medical, but the girl was weak

sometimes. Despite being Shadow Weavers' favourite, she broke the one rule they all understood.

‘Show no weakness.’ Yet Adora was constantly showing weakness that the others couldn’t get away with. She tried to bite down on the resentment that built at that. The girl knew nothing else, and was afraid of one of the most fundamental things. Nobody else in the Horde was afraid of the dark.

She blocked another blow from one of the bots, spun her staff round, and struck it deep into the core processor. One more down. They only deployed ten in these training sims. Kyle couldn’t handle any, Rogelio had got one, and if Adora had been here, they’d split it and then argue over the last one. As it was, nine bots was a challenge. She spun into the low shouldered stance her mom had taught her when she brought her out hunting, and Commander Cobalt was impressed enough with it that he trained her slightly differently around that low hunting style.

She lunged into the middle of the group. They were on simple programming designed for the average cadets, not junior cadets, but she was better. Her and Adora were already on track to become Force Captains as soon as they hit the appropriate merits. Amongst the middle of the bots, her low frame and ability to keep her staff in motion made her more effective than the bots that would struggle to attack without hitting each other.

One of the bots broke off to go for Kyle, charging up a low powered blaster. Rogelio lunged over, landing a claw directly into the primed blaster, the whole thing exploding and throwing him backwards. Lonnie stared for a moment, her mistake—never get distracted—as the bot slammed a leg into her back, sending her staggering. Rogelio would be fine; he was tough. She turned and slammed her staff right into the joint of the leg of the offending bot. As it staggered away, she let go of the staff and drew her knife. Every Horde cadet was issued one.

She had fought like a desert lion, lunging and striking, using the bodies of her enemies as distractions. At one point, she had

ended up close to Kyle, and snatched his knife from his belt. Suddenly with a weapon in each hand, she was a bot-killing machine.

The timer blinked, three minutes over their usual time. Terrible. But, with one person down, it could have been worse. The lights suddenly came on bright as the sim came to an end. Lonnie was panting hard; evening training after a day of lessons was great for unwinding tension but. After morning practice, she just wanted to crawl into bed.

"Excellent work, Cadet Lonnie." The voice of Commander Cobalt broke out over the intercom. "Cadet Kyle, please check on Cadet Rogelio." That was weird. Usually there was a medic nearby enough to check the cadets. "Then please report to the briefing room for a breakdown of what happened in the sim." That wasn't normal, these breakdowns were reserved for the end of the week. She had a feeling.

Rogelio was staggering to his feet, his scales around his arms were charred, but he would be shedding soon anyway. She hoped that would heal that over. Kyle was helping him up, but she grabbed him.

"Get into a terminal, see what's happening," she muttered quickly. Something was wrong, she could feel it. Kyle looked at her confused, but nodded when she gave him the glare that meant her squadmates did what she told them. It worked on almost everyone; Adora seemed to be immune, but other cadets all buckled under it. He rushed off, pulling out a tablet he had acquired from somewhere. (He wasn't supposed to have one but Shadow Weaver turned a blind eye to it. It was useful to have one person in her personal squad with access to the Horde info-net.)

She picked Rogelio up—the scrawny thing was building up some muscle, at least—and she nuzzled her forehead against his. "That was a real good hit. Saving Kyle—we all look out for each other." He grunted something. She could barely understand lizardspeak, but she got confirmation, he agreed.

Kyle whistled, low and long. He was staring at the tablet in his hands. She walked over to see what he was staring at. It was a security feed—*a live security feed*—of the outer courtyard. She recognised it, but not all the bodies in it; dozens if not hundreds of soldiers all surrounding one figure.

The figure made her heart clench. He looked like Mama: same ears, same lithe form, same tail; except it was clearly a man, and he carried a vicious looking knife and a well balanced sword. He was dancing, striking foe after foe, dodging every shot. A tank crew tried to aim at him, and fire, but he rolled up past them so that, if they wanted to shoot, they would hit their own men.

She watched in horror as Shadow Weaver appeared, cackling like she did when she drank too much of the strong berry juice. She got angry on those days. And she was outside, right now, about to use her dark magic on this Magicat. But he did the unthinkable: he picked up one of the standard issue quarterstaves, and hurled it right into the middle of Shadow Weave'rs head. She was a Monster, she had remembered thinking, and now a Knight was here to slay the Monster, looking like Mama.

She was enraptured. If this is what the Horde wanted them to fight, they were dead. This was what a hero looked like but, rather than slaying the Monster, he turned and ran towards the cadet barracks.

No one should be there. She could find him, meet this Magicat, and he could take her back to Mama. Heroes saved children taken by monsters, right? She broke away, sprinting down the corridors. She heard the voice of Commander Cobalt echoing behind her, but that didn't matter. If she could make it in time, she would be able to escape, and get back home. No more training drills, no more Shadow Weaver, no more fighting, finally able to be with her family. Her actual family.

She ran like she had never ran before. She rounded the corridor to the barracks—in front was evidence of the Magicat's handiwork: ten Horde soldiers lying dead. She marveled at the devastation.

The door to the cadets barracks was open. She held her breath and stepped inside.

The room was empty, almost exactly as they had left it this morning, save for one crucial detail: Adora's blanket was lying discarded on the floor. She always made her bed—she was a perfectionist like that—so why was it laying there? Where had the Magicat gone? Where had Adora gone if she was here curled up in her blankets? She had been here… when the Magicat came…

She was gone. The Magicat had come, and taken Adora away. Why? Adora didn't have a family to go home to, she didn't have a mama and a mom who would miss her! Of course Adora got to leave!

Perfect Adora! Shadow Weaver's favorite! She would get blamed for that. Adora leaving, she would suffer! Because Adora was so selfish as to not let everyone who had someone go with her? She couldn't have waited!?

She slammed a fist into Adora's bedpost, feeling a knuckle pop. She didn't care, gritting her teeth through the pain. She felt a hand on her shoulder, and looked up to see the furred form of Commander Cobalt. He just shook his head at her.

"Hope will eat you alive kid," he tried to give some paternal advice. "Do the job that's in front of you." She was so angry, she couldn't contain it. She wailed and wrapped the commander's leg into a hug. He patted the top of her head in a 'I won't report this' way which was basically an admission of caring too much for a Horde officer to a cadet.

Slowly, her heart hardened. Never hope, that way leads to pain. There are no heroes to save you, just fight for you, Kyle, and Rogelio. Nothing else matters. They won't betray you. Her heart took on the grit that the daughter of two Crimson Wastes survivors would envy. And her Mom and Mama would weep over…

Shadow Weaver's Office

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Day After the Coup Attempt

The door to Shadow Weaver's office sat open. The woman had left an open bottle of the rich-smelling juice on the table, a goblet full of the stuff resting next to a report. To Lonnie, the Monster looked tamed, beaten by the false hero, then punished by the King of Monsters—Lord Hordak—for her failure to protect the Fright Zone. They were keeping the amount quiet, but he had escaped, whoever he was, Shadow Weaver knew. She wouldn't be so bitter otherwise. She only got like this, Lonnie had realized, when one of her many schemes failed.

But the reports couldn't be kept quiet, and when even the cadets of Shadow Weaver's special unit were hearing about it, then everyone had heard about it. Nearly a hundred dead, three hundred wounded, four tanks destroyed, and Shadow Weaver's prodigy missing—that one bristled the most. It turned her spit into venom.

"You wanted to see me, Ma'am." She tried to sound formal, not letting the venom bleed into her words. If Shadow Weaver sensed it, she would exploit it; that's what the old witch did. Instead, the woman rose to her feet. It was the first time she had ever seen the woman standing and not floating, but she was still taller than most adults she had met. The woman held up a hand, and Lonnie went silent. Disobedience was death in the Horde.

"Cadet, you have heard the rumours, I assume? That Adora is missing?" Her drawling speech was slurred even further by the drink and the medication she had taken. Lonnie nodded once sharply. "They are true. Adora has been taken, likely to Subtheria, by that mongrel king." Subtheria? The underground that is full of

monsters? And a Mongrel King; Shadow Weaver always called Mama a mongrel. Did the Magicats have a king? She would withhold these questions for now.

“I am sending several squads to attempt to recover her, you have command of your unit until her return.” Until her *return?! She abandons us and she gets to just come back and take back over like nothing happened?!*

“Shadow Weaver, I saw security footage of the” she hesitated—saying “Magicat” in front of a Shadow Weaver with wounded pride was a recipe for disaster, “of the fight.” She settled on saying.

The woman's eyes narrowed. “How did you see such footage, Cadet?” Lonnie gulped once, then stepped forward. “Other cadets in Citron Squad were sharing it around.” The Citron Squad had picked on Rogelio and Kyle the other day before her and Adora got between them; they were owed a bit of punishment. Shadow Weaver relaxed slightly.

“I saw the fighting, and… I want to be taught to fight like that,” she rushed out the words. What she saw was lethal, it was dangerous, and, without being able to fight like that, her squad was dead the second they went up against an actual Princess. She was young enough that, if she threw herself into this training, then she would be ready to fight as soon as she had grown the muscles to be deployed.

“Fight like that?” Shadow Weaver mulled it over for a second. “Tell me, Cadet, what do you know of Mystacor?” She recoiled at that name; everyone knew Mystacor was the land of sorcerers where dark magic was taught, where Shadow Weaver learned her skills. But she also knew Mama spent a bit of time there studying healing magic. Not as much as others but enough to be recognised.

“It’s, like, a school for magic?” she tried to phrase it as ignorance. She knew one thing Shadow Weaver loved was curiosity from her

children. She was a teacher—a cruel vindictive teacher, but a teacher nonetheless.

"Almost. It is a school, an academy, where the sorcerers guard secret knowledge, others come, and they hand out paltry rewards. But one secret that might be shared to those willing to *serve* is the art of a blademaster, allowing one to harness both magic and martial skill." Shadow Weaver explained with some almost reverence. "So, Cadet Lonnie, are you willing to *serve* for such knowledge?" The words sounded like poison injected directly into her veins. But what choice did she have?

"Yes, Shadow Weaver. I would serve the Horde; I would serve you." She got down on one knee like they were supposed to do in the presence of Lord Hordak.

"Your training will be hard… I will need to teach you magic." A chill ran over Lonnie. Magic: the thing the Horde was trying to eliminate. Only Champions were allowed to touch the corrupted secret power. Lonnie held down the fear, and nodded again. "I will need to find you a suitable blademaster. I shall think on this…" She paused, then after a few seconds said, "Resume your training as normal. I shall bring you to learn magic. You can try to implement it into your normal fighting style, but be assured, Lonnie: one day, before you see active duty, I will have forged you into the first Knight of the Fright Zone. I knew you were destined for greatness."

Lonnie stepped out of the chamber, breath rattling out of her. She had started the long walk to damnation. At six years old, she had decided she was worth being condemned to save her friends, and to hurt the Princesses.

A Dark and Hidden Chamber

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Five Years After the Coup Attempt

Isolde awoke—that was a surprise when she had collapsed from both magical exhaustion and blood loss from her injuries on top of that huge, bear-like Force Captain's tank. Her thoughts were: *'At least I have saved Alicor. The Horde will be forced back.'* That was at least as good a reason to die as any, saving a town of innocents from the Horde; Micah would have been proud.

She opened her eyes slowly. Everything hurt, and she realized she was shackled to the floor by long chains. The room was full of fine sand. She pushed herself to her knees and tried to assess the damage: she was bruised all over, a few broken ribs, one eye wouldn't open all the way, and she was fairly certain her hand wouldn't ever work quite the same way again (her fingers bent in the wrong direction). Still, it was better than departing this world entirely. But the question was "why". The Force Captain had been about to smash her head with a mace after she had set his tank to explode with an ice spell over the coolant system, freezing the whole thing over. Trying to cast that, parry a mace, and keep the shield around the triage tent up against the blaster fire was almost impossible for her. She expected the Force Captain to land the next blow and yet now she was on her feet in what was clearly a training hall: dummies, and scrolls of spells sat against the far wall.

She tried to call on her magic. Initially, she thought to teleport out but, in her current state, that would be disastrous. So, instead, she settled on a simple diagnostic spell. As she drew the arcane sigil with her good hand, lightning arced down her body, throwing her muscles into spasm, roaring in pain she fell forward; everything flared, her world became fire.

"*Tut, tut, tut,*" an oh-so-familiar voice echoed out of the darkness. She forced herself back up so she wasn't lying down but instead was sitting in a cross-legged meditative position as the dark shame of Mystacor emerged. A murderer in fine silk. Shadow

Weaver stayed at only the edge of her vision. “We wouldn’t want to break you too quickly, would we?”

Isolde was trained not to react—pain was an illusion, it could be ignored. She turned her head to look directly at the woman who had killed her old mentor. The monstrous form of Darkness was taught, images of her circulated; this is what happens to those who grasp for power that was not theirs to have.

“Is that the plan, then?” Her voice was steady, firm. She could endure pain, she would not scream, even if Shadow Weaver drained every drop of her magic and tore apart her flesh with her twisted stolen power, she would not scream. “Torture?”

The woman darkly chuckled. “Torture, oh, no. I am here to make a deal with you.” She placed a hand on Isolde’s chin, tilting it up to make eye contact. “Congratualtion are twice in order.” Her smug voice made Isolde want to summon a flaming sword and strike her down. “On your achieving the Crescent Moon of Mystacor, and your valiant defense of Alicor.” The woman’s mask obscured her features, but she could tell there was a smug grin underneath it.

Isolde didn’t give her the satisfaction of a response. So, the woman continued, “A remarkable feat at your age—under thirty and becoming a Blademaster. Why, if you had been my apprentice, I would have taken you far.” She sounded almost wistful for the days as a teacher. “And your defense of Alicor, well, I have read Grizzlor’s report. You did so put him out. He wants the troops to have another attempt, take the small settlement. Well, it hardly seems worth the effort.”

“What. Do. You. Want?” she gritted out through her teeth. Shadow Weaver slapped her, claws digging across her skin leaving bloody red gashes.

“You will speak only when spoken too!” the woman growled down at her. “You will learn your place soon enough.”

"As I was saying…" She had straightened herself to her full height, "Lord Hordak would have you executed, but I feel that discarding such a valuable asset would be a waste, don't you agree?"

Isolde just bleed at her.

"Hmm. I suppose it matters little what you want, so I will offer you a choice." She loomed over the prone woman, still blinking away stars, but forcing her broken body to rise. "You can choose life or death?"

Isolde knew she wouldn't give the woman the satisfaction of choosing life; she was already dead as far as the world was concerned, her body simply hadn't caught up yet. But, before she could answer, the woman stepped backwards revealing another figure in the room.

A child—maybe nine or ten—with dark skin and hair in short cornrows. She had a look of grim determination and fatigue found only on the most jaded of veterans. "This is Cadet Lonnie," Shadow Weaver intoned. "She is my apprentice."

Fuck.

Shadow Weaver having an apprentice was a nightmare. Someone who would learn all the dark secrets of Mystacor, someone who would fight against the Rebellion and bring further ruin, and worst of all, it was a child. She had never stopped ruining the lives of children. In a just world, in a fair world, Shadow Weaver would be the only casualty of this war.

"If you choose to die, I shall have Lonnie escort you to the prisons still in these chains—we cannot have you trying anything to escape—and, tomorrow, Lord Hordak will oversee the execution of a Mystacoran mage knight. A good moment of morale boosting for the troops, and I will go back to authorising certain reports and requests." She was glaring at the woman and it was reciprocal. "If, however, you choose to live, you will teach my apprentice the arts of a Crescent Blade of Mystacor, and you will live, and I may

conveniently forget to reinforce Grizzlor before the next big push. Alicor would breathe easy, and little Flyn and Notta would get to live in peace.” Isolde let out a slow breath; she had to mention those two. Kids trapped in war.

She looked at the child, this Cadet Lonnie. She had the build of a warrior, and while the fear of Shadow Weaver was present, she kept it well masked. Perhaps she could mentor her away from the darkest path. She swallowed against the dryness in her throat. Shadow Weaver had her, and she knew it—she had them both. But, with this, she might have a chance, a chance to escape. Patient as the Missing Stars. One day, she would be ready, or one day she would be dead.

“Very well, Apprentice Lonnie. Welcome to the Moonbound Path.”

The Fright Zone Infirmary

Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Seven Years After the Coup Attempt

In the two years of training, Lonnie had never complained, not when the sickness twisted her flesh from Shadow Weavers dark magic, nor when Isolde's teaching brought her past the point of exhaustion. She would become a warrior capable of slaying a Princess, a true champion. Shadow Weaver called her that often, possessive. “Her Knight,” when it was just her and Lonnie, and “The Fright Zone’s Knight” when there were others present.

Isolde was a faun with a light pink skin, one of the antlered folk who she had the vaguest memories of from her childhood. She remembered a village—she couldn’t tell you where—she knew she had a family, but she couldn’t tell you what they looked like,

except one had a tail and green eyes, and the other had grey eyes and a deep laugh. But she had far more memories of Commander Cobalt and Shadow Weaver than she did of whoever lived in that far-off village.

She had finished her training for the day: fourteen hours of form drills, the flowing blades of Mystacor. Isolde called herself a harsh teacher. She had achieved the Crescent Moon of Mystacor at age twenty-two, one of the youngest in history. Lonnie would do it before she was fifteen. By the standards of the outside world, she probably was a harsh taskmaster, punishing failure and offering guidance only where absolutely necessary. By the Horde standards, she was a soft touch. Almost *too* gentle. Lonnie pushed herself far harder than Isolde ever did in her own training.

Shadow Weaver had spent years teaching her the fundamentals of magic, and how to wield what she called the *True Power* of magic, and certainly Lonnie was among the most dangerous sorcerers in the Fright Zone—short of Mortella by a distance but more dangerous than any of the other two-bit sorcerers that joined the Horde's ranks.

With her training with Isolde, she learnt other skills, what her mentor had called the neglected fundamentals: how to perform diagnostics and heal minor injuries like a medic; how to draw moisture from the air or start small, controlled fires (likely to aid in survivalist training); how to use magic to prepare food (not that it had much use in the Fright Zone). These lessons were taught when Lonnie was too tired or injured to continue. But she had a good head and the ability to take notes. Constant note-taking had saved her on more counts than one.

And slowly over two years, she had gone from good by the Horde's—by Shadow Weaver's—exacting standards to great. She was one of the most dangerous warriors in the Fright Zone, a deadly combination of skill and magic. Still, it wasn't enough. Isolde would adjust her form by millimetres rather than centimeters, and would often remark on how far she had come. Sometimes the swordmistress was almost tender with her.

Isolde had demanded and Shadow Weaver had agreed they had gone as far as they could until she had crafted her implements. Not a staff or a wand or a ring or any of the other traditional implements, it would be a pair of swords.

So, Lonnie had been sent off to the northern mines near the city of Dryl—a common target of raids to recover metal—to forge her blades. She had made the journey deep into a strange mine, and returned with metal of a dark colour—enough to forge ten knives, someone had commented. Instead, she would forge two short blades with it.

Nearly two weeks out in the field, she was beginning to enjoy a short deployment, even if she wasn't allowed to bring Rogelio and Kyle. The big lizard was still going through full training, and Kyle was, well, Kyle…

She didn't realize how much she would miss the two of them. She didn't see them anywhere near as much after she had taken on her training but, every night, they curled up in the same bunk. No one checked on them. There were some privileges of being Shadow Weaver's chosen few.

The journey back through the rocky terrain on the back of a skiff carrying chunks of ancient metal was long and lonely; she had time to think. This was her chance. She would prove herself to Shadow Weaver, to Isolde, to Hordak. She would get the opportunity to hunt down that traitor, to burn out the Princesses for everything they did, and they failed to do. She tried to recall her home, burnt to the ground in a Princess attack. She tried to remember her parents, dead now. She remembered Shadow Weaver rescuing her. She would have revenge for their deaths.

When she arrived back, the Fright Zone was bustling with activity. She rushed through crowded streets to make her way to the main compound. When she was most of the way there, a great shape tackled her from the darkness.

[[Lonnie, I have missed you.]] Rogelio was pinning her to the ground and she laughed. He chuckled then his voice hissed out again, [[You must come. Kyle is in the infirmary. He was attacked by cowards.]]

Her heart froze; someone tried to take Kyle from her. Kyle, who couldn't protect himself. Kyle, who was one kind soul in the whole damn Horde. She stood up quickly. Rogelio led the way.

Kyle was in a bad way, hooked up to all manner of machines: a tube down his throat and a vitals machine giving a consistent readout. With a muttered word, she cast her own diagnostic spell, and gasped. He would be lucky to last the night. She shook with rage and grief—another thing she would lose. Kyle was hers and he was being taken from her.

She turned to her only other rock in the storm of the Fright Zone, who looked as frightened as she was. "Who did this?!"

It took half an hour for Rogelio to track down the squad that did it, some old grudge against a former member of Shadow Weavers chosen, taken out on the only truly defenseless member. Their tracks would have been covered by Octavia. She would have vengeance on the one-eyed fishfolk later. For now, she was hunting the bullies who would have killed her partner. She found them in a rec room, lounging on chairs and chuckling. Five grown men, each half out of their armour. Only one stood when they saw her and Rogelio enter, outnumbered over two-to-one. Horde Soldiers of the rank-and-file didn't like taking those odds, they thought the same would apply to Shadow Weavers elite, according to what Rogelio had said. Kyle had certainly tried to run.

She stood between them, humming gently. It was something she did to calm her nerves. She rolled her shoulders once and said in a voice like lead, "Which one of you wants to die?"

They all looked taken aback. The leader—the one who had stood at least—stepped up to her. He was two feet taller than the

thirteen year old. “Do you want to repeat that, Cadet?” He was smirking.

“Gladly, since you seem to be deaf.” Her fists were clenching. She took a controlled breath. *Stay loose.* “Which one of you five fucks wants to die? All of you are going to the infirmary, but one of you ain’t walking out.”

They all were standing now, the lead one leering over her, his hand was going to his knife on his belt. As his hand gripped the pommel, she smiled. “You, then.”

Everything happened very quickly. First, she drew and angled the quarterstaff, igniting the mechanism that extended the pole that could break a Horde bot with a decent swing. It slammed into the leader’s nose with a satisfying *crunch*. As he fell backwards, she spun the staff around into his knee, collapsing him to the floor. Two of the squad rushed at her, but they were clumsy, trying not to trip on their sergeant. She knocked the first blow aside with a slam on the wrist, breaking bone, then thrust the staff into the neck of the third man. She heard something *pop*. That’s good; he’s out. Turning back to the second man, she kicked him, full in the chest while he struggled to grab another weapon with his good hand. He toppled to the ground which became like quicksand with a flick of her wrist. The fourth man had pulled out a blaster. She twisted a hand and conjured ice along his wrist and along the blaster itself. As it discharged, the explosion threw him back across the room. The fifth man was currently pinned under Rogelio. She reached down to the first man, grabbing his officer's badge.

“This is Knight Aspirant Leor, I need a medical team at rec room seven to take five injured to infirmary room three.” She clicked it off, the squad groaned in pain. It took a few minutes for a medical team to arrive, and ten more to get them all to the infirmary.

Lonnie walked with them in silence the entire way. Kyle was still unconscious when they arrived. She walked over to the leader who was coming too but in pain. She looked at him, into his eyes.

“You tried to kill one of the only things I love.” He looked confused at that. “If I wasn’t here, you might have succeeded. I swore to protect them, and I take that very seriously.” There were no medics in the room, just the three of them. Her, the dying Kyle, and this grown man who was involved in Octavia’s campaign of destruction. Lonnie was under no illusions as to the horrors of war; some people didn’t deserve what they had.

Shadow Weaver’s first lesson had been how to take: that was her rule. Isolde had been terrified by that lesson, she had taught Lonnie of the Legend of Light Spinner and how she could steal magic from others. It was anathema to the teachings of Mystacor.

Lonnie was not a student of Mystacor. She gathered twisted vines of dark magic, warm and coarse like sunbaked sand. The man’s eyes went wide. She reached out: he had a full life, the strength of a soldier. It all twisted and drained away into the spell, boiling in a sea of sickly energy. She grasped it. It was like trying to hold sand in her fingers: it was quickly running out. She moved; it was only a few dozen feet, but it felt like a marathon. Like her laps of the Fright Zone, in what felt like a lifetime struggling against a serpent that was this man's life trying to wrench free of the dark magic. She stumbled and fell, but something caught her, an angel of scales helped her to her feet.

Empowered by the life of the dead sergeant, she forced life into Kyle. It was Dark Magic used to save a life, two things that shouldn’t exist. Corrupted Magic stood against the worldly order, while Unconditional Love used to save a life stood against the Horde’s teachings. It didn’t matter to Lonnie at that moment. She collapsed over Kyle’s bed, resting her head against his chest. The young boy’s breathing began to steady, no longer a rasp. She hummed against him. Rogelio wrapped his tail around the two of them.

They were safe. Tomorrow, she would face her punishment. Tomorrow, she would forge her swords. Tomorrow, she would take the next step on the path to becoming something terrible.

But, for tonight, she was a young girl with a crush on a dork and safe in the arms of her closest friends.

In the darkness of the Black Garnet chamber, Shadow Weaver viewed the whole exchange, and she smiled.

The Sorcerer's Hall

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Nine Years After the Coup Attempt

Lonnie had improved even further since forging her swords made of a strange metal that resonated with magic. She had become a lethal weapon of Shadow Weaver's will.

She had awoken before the morning muster and, detangling herself from Rogelio, had dressed and made her way to the Study Hall. She had drank from a canteen and ate a brown ration bar en-route. Today would be standard drills. The Mystacoran woman wouldn't sign off on her becoming a full knight until she reached her fourteenth year in the Horde which seemed arbitrary to Lonnie, but it was something to do with the customs of Mystacor, and Shadow Weaver had agreed, another leverage point over Lonnie. Just as she had protected her from repercussions from Octavia's squad.

She moved as swiftly as she could when she heard it: the sound of fighting, metal clashing against steel, spells sung into life. She rushed to the sound, drawing her blades. It was coming from the Throne Room?

The devastation was obvious: a dozen Horde soldiers, including Hordak's elite guard, lay dead or dying. Some with bodies

smashed, others with throats cut and limbs severed. She could recognise the style, Crescent Moon Style. Her Blademistress was free?

She slammed through the doorway to the throne room. There was a scene of utter carnage, just like nine years ago: two clearly heroic figures stood facing the monsters of Lonnie's childhood. Shadow Weaver standing against a Knight of Mystacor, her magics barely holding back the tide of blades and spells from her old swordmistress, and Lord Hordak, fighting a beast of a man wielding a mace designed to crush wearing armour the colour of a forest: dark green and wood brown. Evidence of his martial skill lay scattered around, groaning and broken.

Incanting a spell as she was taught, she coated the edges of her blades, one in flame and the other in frost. She lunged; she could save Shadow Weaver. Isolde was striking at Shadow Weaver's shield, never giving the Sorcerers the opportunity to conjure her dark magic. It was only hearing the incantation of her apprentice that the Moon-Dancing Knight turned, parrying a slash from the girl she had watched grow from a scared child to a terrifying monster. She had held this girl while she cried over some horrible deed she had done two years before, and now she was going to have to kill her or die.

Lonnie was utterly focused. She had fought this woman a thousand times in practice bouts, and a thousand times she had been left on the ground. Today, there was no practice. Isolde: her mentor, her one confidant, her ally against Shadow Weaver's cruelty, had betrayed her. Just as Mama had betrayed her years ago, giving her to Hordak. Just as Adora had betrayed her by leaving. Just as the men of Octavia's squad had betrayed the trust of the Fright Zone. She would pay like them.

With a growl—she didn't dare turn her face from the fighting—she managed to get out "Help Lord Hordak." Shadow Weaver summoned up lightning and the man breaking the neck of the last of Hordak's guards had to dodge.

Master and Apprentice were facing off. She glared at the older knight who looked at her with sorrow and determination. Both stayed still, barely breathing. Behind them, the sound of a titanic clash filled the chamber.

They both began to incant spells at the same time, lunging with their blades drawn, a wall of fire connected to a cone of absolute frost. Boiling steam exploding between them, obscuring everything to an outside observer. They lunged at the same instant into the steam, skin blistering. Both had long been taught to ignore such pain; each had tricks for surviving.

She had drawn a circle in the air with the tip of her sword, letting ice run down the blade to coat her skin, shielding her from the boiling heat for a few seconds. Her mentor met her in the middle, a swirl of air throwing the boiling vapor away from her. The swords met—her mentor had recovered her blades; she had discovered where Shadow Weaver had hidden them a year ago. The resonant metal met the silver-edged blades with a blinding speed. The two danced; each twist of the wrist or shift of the hips could spell instant death for the other.

She had knocked aside blows, and had hers parried in return, but there was one immutable fact of the fight: she was holding her ground. Lonnie, a cadet in the Horde not yet full grown, was fighting a Knight of the Crescent Moon, one of the champions of Mystacor, and she was matching her blow for blow.

She was muttering incantation after incantation, spell after spell, never letting up. Her breath: that was what mattered, the first lesson. Magic was life, life was breath. She had kept it going as long as she could. In each moment, she felt the tug of the dark, to wield Shadow Weaver's teachings, but she refused. She would win this in the Mystacoran style. Her final test, life or death. The same choice that was offered to Isolde years ago.

Her mentor had done the same, spells flying between them, broken apart by spells woven to counter the other. In a final, terrifying moment, both saw their opening and struck. There was

a sudden burst of light as two spells crashed against each other and reality *bled at the seams*. When the light cleared, Lonnie felt blood dribbling down over her head, and her right eye seemed blind. But her left sword, dulled of magical energy, was buried in Isolde's chest.

The older knight's fingers twitched, and the sudden clatter of two swords crashing into the ground was heard. One hand grasped firmly onto her wrist, the other the back of her head. Lonnie blinked blood out of her eyes. The shallow gash hadn't rendered her blind, it just bled like a bitch. The older woman pulled gently so their heads were pressed together, forehead pressed between the stub of her missing and her one remaining antler.

"Well done, Lonnie. I hope you're proud." It was a sneer, but under it, a layer of genuine pride. "You're the first Knight of the Fright Zone." The woman coughed, and blood was speckled in the air. "The Bulwark—" she coughed again, "against all that is good." She smiled a crooked smile, several teeth cracked and broken. "Good luck, child. I hope you survive. I hope it is worth it." The woman muttered an incantation, one that Lonnie recognised. She threw herself backwards with every ounce of remaining strength.

Isolde, Knight of Mystacor, teacher of the Bulwark of the Horde, went from a pale waif of a woman to a burning star. The room exploded into light. Everyone was thrown to the ground. One of Lonnie's blades, forged to fight the princesses, melted into slag. Both Isolde's blades were sublimated by the heat.

Lonnie blinked against the black spots in her vision, and couldn't hear over the ringing in her ears. She lifted her head. One arm was broken. She could tell that, but her right arm, with sword hilt still clenched inside it, was only bruised. As her vision cleared, she watched in horror.

The man in the suit had recovered. He stood over the prone form of Shadow Weaver, his mace raised high and ready to strike. It would be a heartbeat, and both her mentors would be dead.

There was a way, she knew. Power still hung in the air, the last vestiges of Isolde's strength fading into light. Lonnie grasped each tiny fragment, and consumed them. Lights snuffed into Darkness and, in the time it took to blink, Lonnie stood, moving into the shadow of this titan of a Man, her blade raised high.

She caught the mace on the flat of her blade with a resounding ***clang.*** The figure stared down at her. She had imagined a monster, bestial looking like Grizzlor. Instead it was just a man, long mustache hanging loose, sweat beading on his brow.

He mouthed something that looked to Lonnie like the *'A child?'* or perhaps he said it and her ears had not yet recovered. As he finished to utter the word, he was already in motion. The man was exceptionally skilled, and Lonnie doubted she could beat two masters of warfare in one day. Instead, she grabbed the head of the mace, channeling magic of the frozen north, she sent ice running down the head of the mace to his arm. With her booted leg, she kicked his foot driving her heel into his armoured toes. He wouldn't notice, but ice covered there too.

The warrior looked surprised. As she muttered "For the Horde," the world went red. The sound of a cannon firing filled the chamber with another deafening roar, striking the armoured figure frozen in place, and throwing him and Lonnie across the room.

Lonnie had barely recovered, shielded from the blast by the warrior. Hordak stalked over, and Shadow Weaver was rising to her feet. Impossibly, the man twitched, his armour was rent and torn by the blast but it had kept him alive.

Hordak approached with a cannon held in his augmented fist. Shadow Weaver rested against the stairs to the throne. The man struggled to a seated position. Lonnie, not wanting Hordak to get close, scrambled over despite her protesting limbs, and pressed a blade to man's throat.

"Surrender," her voice was far calmer than the adrenaline coursing through her body made her feel. "I do not want to kill you," she

pressed the blade closer, “but I will.”

“What’s your name?” the man asked, as if he was asking on a routine inspection and not a foiled assassination attempt. She shook her head. This bastard was crazy, but she had won.

“I am Lonnie, Knight of the Fright Zone.” She felt proud of that. Isolde had granted it to her far earlier than expected. She hoped Hordak would allow the title, but she was feeling grandiose. “I am the shield against your tyranny.”

The man gave a small nod, so as to not disturb the blade. His eyes were filled with fury. “Then I, Duncan of Eternos, surrender myself to your custody, Knight Lonnie.”

Hordak reached over and placed one hand on her shoulder. “Good work,” he paused as if to say “cadet”—the shape of the word familiar in his mouth—but he was not deafened by the explosions. “Knight”

As Lonnie watched, more figures entered the room: guards who would have been too late to help. “Secure the prisoner,” she heard herself saying. “Take him to Isolde’s cell.” The guards picked up this Duncan of Eternos. He went without a further fight.

Lonnie approached the great scar in the throne room. Half her focus lay in ruin, her mentor and only knowledgeable connection to the outside was gone, reduced to ash.

She would adapt, forge a new blade, always adapt, always survive. Put one foot in front of the other. Punish the traitors, keep moving forwards. Learn more of the secrets, never stop or you will fall.

She was a survivor born of the feuds of the desert, tempered in mother’s love, and then forged in the Fright Zone. She would not fail, the Horde was hers to protect. No matter the cost.

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